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October 4, 2026
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OMR communities push back against UPI commercial levy

FOMRRA and ADDA petition National Payments Corporation of India for a flat ₹5 UPI merchant discount rate on maintenance. They want the government to notify apartment maintenance collections as an essential utility category

The Federation of OMR Residents Associations (FOMRRA), representing over 250 high-density gated communities along Chennai's IT Corridor, has joined hands with community governance platform ADDA (3Five8 Technologies) to formally submit a joint representation to the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) and the Ministry of Finance.

Backed by a national coalition representing approximately 2,00,000 housing societies and Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs), the representation calls for apartment maintenance collections to be notified as an essential utility category eligible for a flat ₹5 Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions above ₹2,000, rejecting the proposed 0.4% commercial levy slated for 15 October 2026.

According to a press release, the coalition cautions that treating residential maintenance payments under standard commercial Person-to-Merchant (P2M) rules will severely penalise middle-class citizens, reverse years of digital payment adoption and impose an unsustainable overhead on non-profit communities.

Under the upcoming UPI MDR framework, standard P2M collections above ₹2,000 attract a 0.4% fee (capped at ₹300). While commercial enterprises can absorb transaction fees or factor them into retail profit margins, housing societies operate strictly on a hand-to-mouth, cost-recovery basis, says the press release.

An RWA calculates its maintenance fees solely on actual expenditure incurred during the year for essential shared amenities such as security personnel, water tankers, lift maintenance, housekeeping, and common-area electricity, the release adds.

An RWA calculates its maintenance fees solely on actual expenditure incurred during the year for essential shared amenities

'Palm promotion' in Pallikaranai

On Gandhi Jayanthi, the banks and the island portion of Pallikaranai Anai Eri (a lake located near the gated community Purva Windermere which is in Medavakkam bordering on Pallikaranai) witnessed a palm seed planting drive supported by NSS students, volunteers of local communities, Dream Kalam NGO and Purva Pasuma Karangal Trust.

According to a press release, inaugurating the Palm Seed Planting drive, S. Rajamohamed, a retired joint director of horticulture and currently, visiting faculty at Landscape Architecture, Anna University pointed out that Palymyrah palm (*Borassus flabellifer*), a tree of thousand uses and the state tree of Tamil Nadu, need to be sown along the banks of any waterbody to conserve soil and moisture.

He also explained the method of sowing the palm seeds to the participants which included students. More than 500 Palmyrah palm seeds were sown both in island portion and on the banks of Anai Eri.

Planting of Neer maruthu (Terminalia arjuna) to commence shortly, by getting saplings from Forest Department, said Rajamohamed.

J.Shankar, founder and president, Dream Kalam, Paul Sabastian, chief administrative officer, Elite Group of Schools Redhills & Gummudipondi and P. Ramesh Kumar, NSS programme officer, Asan Memorial College of Arts and Science, S. Jayagopal, director of Yatha Green Council of India participated in this campaign.

There was a special word of praise from the participants for Arjun Sankar, the coordinator of all these environmental activities, the press release added.



‘A police booth is required at Pudhupakkam junction’

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Motorists navigating the Pudhupakkam junction – the intersection of Vandalur Kelambakkam Road and Pudhupakkam Main Road – would face significant risks if they relied solely on the traffic signals.

Accidents are often a near miss, and waiting to happen, say motorists who navigate the junction frequently.

Pudhupakkam residents have requested the Traffic Wing of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate to set up a police booth and deploy personnel to prevent accidents. At the junction, pedestrians and motorists jump signals to reach their destinations without knowing the consequences of risking for a few minutes.



Motorists often jump signals at Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road.

Motorists from the Kelambakkam and Pudhupakkam regions cross when vehicles are moving on Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road. Similarly, many motorists on this stretch jump signals and drive rashly, posing a risk to both pedestrians and fellow motorists.

It is better to slow down and look in all directions, and negotiate as motorists have scant regard for traffic rules, says A. Kumar, a motorist. In addition, along the junction, there are no speed breakers. The motorists come at a breakneck speed without stopping.

The signals do not help in regulating the traffic as people drive according to their convenience, creating confusion among their fellow motorists, K. Anand pointed out. At the earliest, traffic police personnel must be deployed before a fatal accident happens.

The pedestrian signal is operated when motorists from Siruseri and Pudhupakkam regions can turn left and right to proceed towards Kelambakkam and Mambakkam. As motorists from the above mentioned regions jump lanes, to negotiate quickly, pedestrians can be hit. Also, the pedestrians jump over the medians and cross amidst the traffic on Vandalur - Kelambakkam Road.

Long wait for a shelter



Commuters at Kovalam bus haltover on Kovalam - Kelambakkam Road, along East Coast Road, have requested the Kovalam Village Panchayat to facilitate a shelter-cum-seating facility.

Commuters either stand in the open or take shelter under shops. Some wait inside the share autos that ply between Kovalam - Kelambakkam Road and Kelambakkam.

From the haltover, commuters board buses towards West Tambaram, Adyar, Thiruvanmiyur, Thiruvottiyur, Kilambakkam, and Island Grounds.

“When there are a good number of commuters, people struggle for space. A shelter and a seating facility must be installed at the earliest,” says N. Sultana, a commuter.

TEXT AND PHOTO: T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@ thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number.

Farmers market comes to Pallikaranai

Inspired by the organic farmers market in T. Nagar, Aram Thinai is extending the initiative to this region

If you are looking for fresh produce sourced directly from farmers then head to SS Mahal in Pallikaranai today. A new organic farmers markets is being launched from October 4 and will be held on the first Sunday of every month.

Inspired by the success of organic farmers market in T. Nagar, Aram Thinai, a climate action organisation is launching their second Aram Organic Farmers Market in Pallikaranai. Such markets across Chennai are emerging as spaces for conscious consumption, farmer-consumer relationship building and knowledge sharing.

The market has 20-30 stalls of organic farmers, women groups and social entrepreneurs with a range of organic and eco-friendly products. There will be more than 20 varieties of greens, 15 varieties of traditional rice and a range of organic grocery, value added products, eco-friendly cleaning products and some organic dishes. In a release, Karthik G., co-founder, Aram Thinai, said they want to ensure fair price to both farmers and consumers.

Like some practices that is followed in its T. Nagar market (held on the second Sunday of every month), this one is also a zero single use plastic market. Consumer have to bring their own containers and bags to buy things and the farmers pack everything in paper covers or glass bottles.

Consumers have to bring their own bottles to buy organic cold pressed oil, and more than 100 consumers are doing this in T. Nagar.

“In the last one year in T. Nagar, we have saved more than 1100 plastic bottles, 2200 plastic plates/cutleries and 33,000 plastic covers. We are enabling behavioural change among consumers to reduce single use plastic,” said Karthik.

For details, call 8939138207 / 7449138207

Elders Day celebrated at gated community in Padur

On the occasion of World Elders’ Day (October 1), a gala evening brought together the senior citizens of Mantri Synergy, a gated community in Padur.



Seniors shared their happiness, their sense of belonging and what being a Mantrite meant to them. There were also touching moments as they fondly remembered loved ones they had lost.

The seniors were felicitated with a rose and a commemorative shawl, followed by “Brewstar refreshing”. Games such as tambola added laughter and cheer, making the evening a memorable celebration of togetherness and the community spirit, said a release.

How accessible is your community?



A scene from *Block A For Accessibility*

LIFFY THOMAS

How accessible is your apartment community? That's the central idea of this short film *Block A For Accessibility*, released with a private screening at PVR Satyam Cinemas on September 25. The 20-minute CBFC-certified film by YWTC (Yes, We Too Can!!!) Charitable Trust, in collaboration with Fiserv and United Way Mumbai as the CSR partner, is a story of care, community, and design.

The film revolves around Natarajan, an ageing father, who after starting to use a wheelchair keeps himself isolated from the vibrant life of his apartment complex because he does not want to trouble his son. A sudden accident at the building's stairs becomes a turning point for the entire community. The film follows the internal realisation of the association secretary and the decisive action of the builder.

Natarajan's character is played by a deaf person, Ravi Kumar. Voice was given by Umapathy, a wheelchair user. Most of the cast and crew are persons with disabilities, including the director. The film has sign language interpretations along with subtitles.

The film addresses a universal civic necessity: accessible housing that accommodates an ageing population and ensures people of all abilities live with independence and dignity.

For a screening of "Block A For Accessibility" at your apartment complex/workplace, write to yeswetoocan@gmail.com or call yeswetoocan@gmail.com

Handrails: a silver jubilee gift



Not many residents at Raheja Regency, a 25-year-old apartment community in MRC Nagar, likely know the two people who were instrumental in getting handrails installed at strategic points in the society recently. Nonagenarian Arjun Krishna and septuagenarian Vasantha Arjun were too modest to talk about this accessibility feature and agreed to give their names after much prodding by this journalist.

One of the earliest residents of this gated community, when the couple were part of the resident association, they got handrails fixed at most of the blocks some 20 years ago. These have been patronised by all, especially the senior citizens. But the community could do with some more, and the couple themselves have experienced the practical difficulty in not having them.

"One of the ladies has even fallen not having a railing to hold on to it," says Vasantha. The couple sponsored the entire cost of installing the handrailings at some new locations as a gift to the community that has been their home for the last 25 years (the couple marked 25 years of staying in the community this June).

Pool lift: for easy swimming

Madhavi Latha Prathigudupu's day is not complete without accessing the swimming pool at her gated community in Arumbakkam. Since 2022, what makes this common amenity accessible for this para-athlete is the pool lift that was incorporated.

The swimming champion cannot do without being in the pool and her late father had to help her get into the waters. She convinced Triumph Apartments, a community with 108 flats where she owns one, to make the pool accessible. "Before installing the pool lift, we had a demonstration done by the manufacturer with the committee members to get their approval," says Madhavi, president of YWTC Charitable Trust.

Today, she goes independently into the pool (she controls the lift pool through a remote) and most importantly has raised the importance of



having inclusive amenities at gated communities not just for those with disabilities but even for use by the elderly. There was no ramp when she moved in to the community; the association did not just construct one for access to her block but made the improvisation at other towers as well.

Accessibility standards of the National Building Code insist on a barrier-free built environment and all common facilities accessible to all people. "It's your right, so ask the builder for such accessible features before investing in a flat," she adds.

Sensory park: designed by special parents



In August, the Community Living Association for Parents of Special Citizens (CLAPS) celebrated four years of moving into an inclusively designed campus at Tiruvallur, near Poondi reservoir.

A group of 50 parents of young adults with special needs got together to conceptualise such a model in a 8.5 acre residential campus that comes with a host of universally designed and accessible amenities.

Latha Krishnan and Vaijayanthi Srinivasan, both special parents, say the activity centre, swimming pool, and sensory park are the most popular among the young adults aged 20 and above.

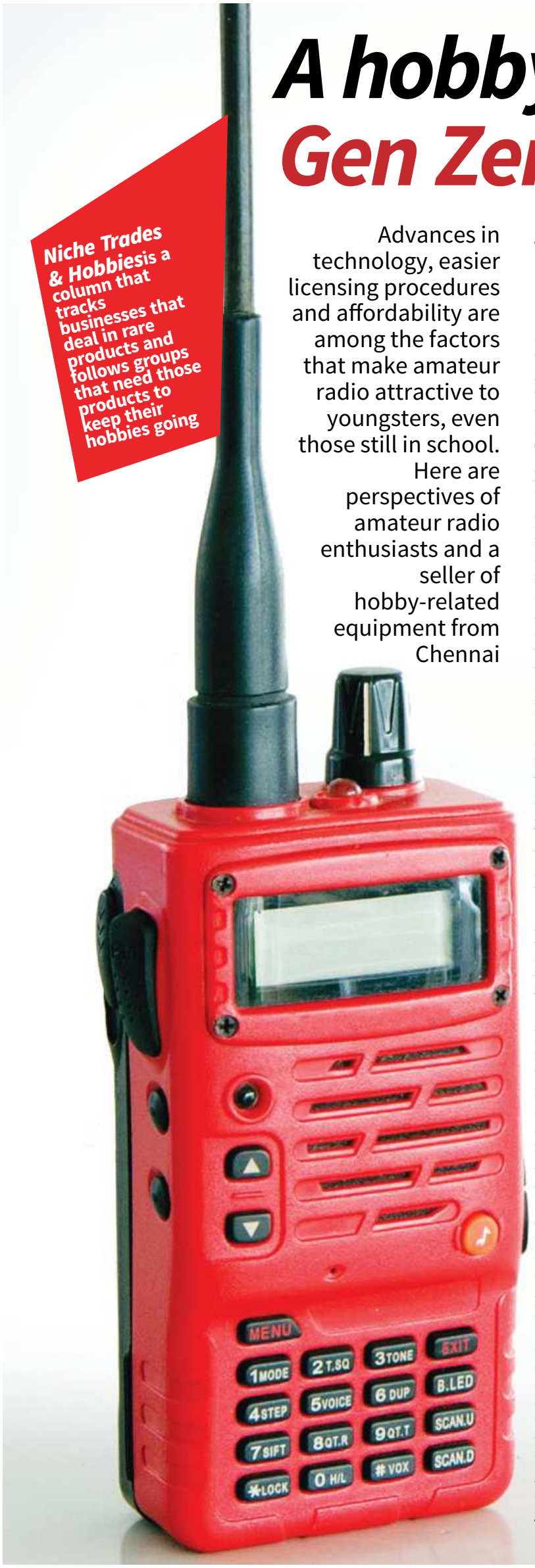
Unlike the apartment communities where they faced many challenges, here everything is customised in keeping with the different needs of the children, a majority are on the spectrum, some with Down's Syndrome and intellectually disability.

The sensory park, for instance, is a hit for those with autism and has equipment with different textures. The activity centre allows them choose programmes as per one's moods and likes. To oversee the children, there are many external professionals, including the warden, supervisor and activity head.

Niche Trades & Hobbies is a column that tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going

A hobby evolves to meet Gen Zers on their terms

Advances in technology, easier licensing procedures and affordability are among the factors that make amateur radio attractive to youngsters, even those still in school. Here are perspectives of amateur radio enthusiasts and a seller of hobby-related equipment from Chennai



LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There is usually an apocalyptic air to how Ham radio is perceived. The Ham radio enthusiast is readily visualised as trudging into a land overtaken by a massive disaster and where all technology-based communication lines outside the amateur-radio sphere have broken down. The enthusiast has morphed into a saviour, connecting with a fellow hobbyist elsewhere in the "universe" and communicating a local situation, dire and distressing, amidst the static and crackle of radio communication, to reach help to the suffering. This description is indeed fact-aligned. Ham radio enthusiasts do take centre stage during disasters. One witnessed that during the Kerala floods of 2018 and closer home, in the harrowing first week of December 2015 in Chennai. But distress communication is only one of the things riding on amateur radio air waves. Net sessions (as on-air meetups of Ham radio hobbyists are known) are also defined by banter, in fact, more by small talk than SOS calls. And do not be surprised if the banter is punctuated with Gen Z lingo.

N. Deepan (call sign VU2DPN), a key member of Madras Amatuer Radio Society (MARS), points out that the Ham radio hobby has never been as accessible to youngsters as it is now. From licensing to practising the hobby, the procedures of initiation and the operation of the equipment have become ridiculously simple. Having seen 63 summers and getting started on the hobby around four decades ago, Deepan is at a vantage point to talk about the hobby's evolution.

The Wireless Planning and Coordination wing (WPC) is responsible for conducting Amateur Station Operator's Certificate (ASOC) examination and issuing the license.

Deepan underlines the examinations have become simpler as technology has organically taken certain "subjects" off the table. And the removal of this barrier encourages the entry of youngsters. Anyone aged 12 and above can appear for the exam and get the license. "Where it took one or two years to get a license, it takes approximately one month," observes Deepan, noting that objective questions have replaced the earlier pattern of examination.

And the new license holder can hit the ground running, the process of getting started on the hobby also having become facile. EchoLink, Z3 DMR, and Droidstar allow licensed operators to communicate using just a phone with other amateur radio enthusiasts. Once the license is validated, usually within 24 hours, the software can be used. And that obviates the need to invest in ham radio equipment; that can wait. Deepan has seen the ham radio equipment move from valves to transistors, ICs and now Software Defined Radio (SDR). With advancing technology, the equipment has shrunk, and so has their prices. Deepan attributes the fall in prices to the shift from imported equipment to local dealerships (to sell ham radio equipment, a dealer's license is required).

That brings us to someone like Gaurav Srivatsava and his wife Shivangi Gaurav, both ham radio license holders and diehard enthusiasts, and beyond that, owners of Radio Brewery in Iyyapanthangal (radiobrewery.com), which sells amatuer radio equipment. Shivangi largely manages the business while Gaurav continues to work in the IT sector. Their own personal struggles in finding reliable and cost-effective equipment locally had crystallised into this business venture in 2018. Gaurav recalls that besides importing, Ham radio enthusiasts in Chennai were dependent on a couple of dealers in Delhi. The hobbyists would together buy in bulk to keep prices within their comfort range. Among those who encouraged them to start this business was Deepan, one of Gaurav's mentors and supporters.


Malini D

Among factors that augur well for the hobby, Gaurav says, is the portability of the ham radio gear. He recalls the time when valve radios, measuring six by six feet, "appropriated" a room in exchange for the joy of communicating on amateur radio air waves. Fast forward to now, a low-powered ham radio equipment can "fit into a small bread box". Deepan notes that even if one were to route their ham radio communication through an amateur radio satellite, the allied equipment, which includes SDR dongle, dish antenna and up converter or transverter, is easy on the back, being eminently portable. Both Deepan and Gaurav have noticed youngsters taking to the hobby. Gaurav points out his daughter Pari Gaurav (VI2JXB/ KN6GRI, US amateur radio identifier ID), 19 years old now, cleared the WPC examination at age 12. Deepan's daughter, Malini D. (VU3JJT) is also an avid ham radio enthusiast. Even youngsters without any precedent of ham radio engagement in their families are gravitating towards the hobby for the doors of communication it opens in various parts of the world. Deepan notes, "On the Net, all radio ham hobbyists connect and converse as equals."

To sum up, this hobby seems to have been made for Gen Zers (and the ones following them too) for two reasons. It is a generation that derives its strength and purpose from communication, even with those they will never meet in real life, and this hobby is geared to that. And two, this generation thrives on volunteering, and this hobby can provide opportunities for that during extremely harrowing times.

Three-year-old undergoes liver transplant



Rainbow Children's Hospital performed a liver transplant on a three-year-old patient diagnosed with the rare systemic disorder called Langerhans Cell Histiocytosis (LCH). According to a press release, the procedure was successful and it was considered a complicated case due to an underlying congenital abnormality of kidneys causing recurrent urinary tract infections.

The child underwent a living donor liver transplant, receiving a portion of his father's liver. The transplant was performed by Dr. Mettu Srinivas Reddy, Group Director - Department of Liver Transplantation & HPB Surgery; along with Dr. Somashekara H R, Senior Consultant - Paediatric Hepatology & Liver Transplantation. A team of multidisciplinary doctors were also part of the procedure.

The is yet another case highlighting the importance of a multidisciplinary approach in managing complex paediatric conditions, adds the release.

On the occasion, Dr. Somashekara said, "This was an exceptionally complex case because we were not dealing with a single problem. We had to manage a rare systemic disease with severe liver involvement, while also dealing with the limitations that the liver dysfunction placed on chemotherapy. When recurrent infections emerged, we had to identify and correct the underlying urinary abnormality before the child could proceed to transplant. Each decision had to be carefully coordinated with the next. The involvement of our hemato - oncology, hepatology and liver transplant, nephrology and urology teams allowed us to address these challenges together and take the child through treatment in a planned and coordinated manner."

Adding on to this case, Dr. Mettu Srinivas Reddy said, "Performing a liver transplant in a 3.5-year-old child with significant liver involvement and multiple associated medical complications requires meticulous planning at every stage. Before transplantation, the child had to be stabilised and the recurrent infections and congenital urinary abnormality had to be appropriately addressed. From the surgical perspective, ensuring that the child was medically optimised and ready for transplantation was critical. The successful transplant was made possible through close coordination between the transplant, paediatric, oncology, nephrology and urology teams, followed by careful post-transplant monitoring and continued treatment for the underlying condition."

Learners drive learning at Kelambakkam school

Sarvalokaa recently hosted its Learner-Led Conference, placing learners at the centre of conversations about their own learning





Recently, Chettinad - Sarvalokaa Education International School, located within the green Chettinad Health City campus in Kelambakkam, organised a Learner-Led Conference (LLC) which places learners at the centre of their learning journey, encouraging them to confidently present, explain and reflect on their experiences while developing agency and ownership.

According to a press release, the initiative reflects the school's broader approach to experiential and collaborative learning, nurturing communication, confidence, problem-solving, reflection and real-world skills beyond academics.

The press release adds that unlike a traditional parent-teacher meeting, a learner-led conference gives learners the responsibility to present, explain and reflect on what they have learnt. Learners speak about their understanding, challenges, progress and experiences, thereby developing learner agency - the ability to make choices, take responsibility and actively participate in their own learning

Chettinad - Sarvalokaa Education International School is a Nature- integrated Cambridge International school that places strong emphasis on joyful, experiential and holistic learning, says the press release.

RmKV's innovations in silk saris

In its 102nd year, RmKV is launching 18 new innovations in silk saris this festive season. The special showcase 'Weaves & Wonders' in Chennai will offer visitors an opportunity to experience the stories first hand.

The saris on display include Ragamala, Kalpavruksham, Koorai Kattam, Bel Jaal Lino, Rettai Kili, Poo Thoranam, Poo Gopuram, Mayil Thuttham Korvai, Golden Kagome, Japanese Bijinga, Muppagam Naturals, Kili Kodi Lino, Chevvandhi Kattam, Madras Kattam and Golden Pearl Kattam.

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A power start to the day

As an extension of its free noon meal scheme, Ramakrishna Mission Vivekananda College will start serving breakfast for students from economically poor backgrounds from October 5 onwards

LIFFY THOMAS



There is now a lip-smacking incentive for students of Ramakrishna Mission Vivekananda College in Mylapore to be on the campus before 8.30 a.m. The college is starting a free breakfast scheme for students, which will be inaugurated on October 5 by Swami Satyajnanananda, president of Sri Ramakrishna Math.

From mint coriander idly with mixed dhal sambar, veg rava khichdi with peanut chutney, wheat vermicelli veg upma with green moong dal gravy, the menu curated by NGO Akshaya Patra Foundation promises to be both interesting and wholesome. It will be brought from the Foundation's kitchen on Greams Road in Thousand Lights every working day to feed approximately 600 students.

For this autonomous institution, this is a extension of its free noon meal programme that it has been offering since 2004 to students from less privileged backgrounds enrolled with the college.

Approximately 600 students are currently registered as beneficiaries under this 'no cost noon meal scheme'. Each beneficiary is issued an identity card to avail of this facility, and an average of 450 students benefit from the scheme every working day, says a note shared by the college management.

Students enrolled for the noon meal scheme will be added to the breakfast scheme, and this is entirely supported by Akshaya Patra.

The college management feels the breakfast scheme would help address the decline in admissions to undergraduate programmes by providing additional welfare support to economically disadvantaged students, improve attendance and promise a healthy start to the day.

A spokesperson from Akshaya Patra Foundation said that this would be the first college in Tamil Nadu where it will be initiating such a programme. In Chennai, they currently serve breakfast to 55 government-aided schools.

"The breakfast menu in college would be slightly different from what we serve children at schools. It is a pilot programme and the menu is based on regional preferences, ensuring it is both wholesome and nutritious," says the spokesperson.

Strengthening academia-industry connection



B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology recently hosted an international industry collaboration and offer letter presentation ceremony with Crescent Global Outreach Mission (CGOM) and ADEEB Group, marking a significant step toward strengthening international industry-academia partnerships and creating global career opportunities for students.

Ansari Wahid, Chief Executive Officer, ADEEB Group, Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates, was the chief guest.

The ceremony focused on strengthening international industry collaboration and enhancing students' exposure to global employment opportunities. Through this association, the institution is creating avenues for students to connect with international organisations, understand global industry expectations, and develop the skills needed to build successful careers beyond national boundaries, a release said.

A key highlight of the programme was the presentation of offer letters to the selected students.

The interactions emphasised the importance of industry-academia collaboration, international exposure, employability enhancement, and global career development in preparing students for the evolving demands of the international workforce, the release added.

Rally on heart health

In observance of World Heart Day, VS Hospitals organised a four-km rally to spread awareness on heart health. On the occasion, the hospital launched its emergency helpline number 044 - 69698000.

According to a press release, former DGP C. Sylendra Babu flagged off the event at VS Hospitals, Tondiarpet, in the presence of Dr. S. Subramanian Chairman and Managing Director, VS Hospitals, Dr. S. Sundar, Medical Director, Muthu Subramanian, Executive Director, and Prassanna Srinivasan, Group COO.

Sylendra Babu, in his address, stressed on the importance of physical activity to be healthy. Close to 300 people took part including healthcare professionals and members of the public.



Donate your golu padi

Thuvakkam wants families who are not planning to arrange the golu steps (*padi*) or have them stacked on their loft to give it to them. The NGO will be using them to showcases projects in the field of social, environment, conversation and volunteering, some of the main areas they have been working on. The steps will be collected from the houses of residents.

The Navaratri celebration-cum-golu display is happening from October 11 to 20; 6 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. at Thuvakkam head office in Alwarthirunagar. Public are welcome to come and see the display.

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